



PROCEDURE

No Further Action (NFA) Referrals – Management and Storage

Scope (Staff):	All NMHS Mental Health (MH) Staff: Clinical and Administration
Scope (Area):	All NMHS MH Areas

1. Aim

To ensure all incoming non-actioned clinical referral documentation is appropriately stored, archived and retained in accordance with minimum sentencing requirements. This procedure also aims to clarify the definition of a non-actioned referral and non-activated patient information that does not fit the criteria for filing in accordance with the NFA storage requirements outlined below.

2. Risk

Non-compliance with this procedure will impact on the following risk categories:

Culture	☐	Organisational Development	☐
Emergency Management	☐	Policy & Legislative Compliance	☒
Fiscal Responsibility	☐	Quality of Patient Care	☐
Governance & Accountability	☒	Research & Innovation	☐
Information Communications Technology	☐	Staff Safety & Wellness	☐
Facility Management	☐	Workforce Planning	☐
Medical Equipment	☐	Other	☐

3. Key Points

North Metropolitan Health Service Mental Health (NMHS MH) undertakes records management in accordance with legislative and business regulations for record keeping. All clinical and administrative staff has a responsibility to be aware of and to adhere to these record keeping practices to ensure that non-actioned clinical information is archived appropriately and retained for the mandatory retention period.

A non-actioned referral is a referral document (paper based or electronically generated) which has not resulted in the client being activated into a mental health program. *However* some non-activated referrals do not fit the criteria for filing in accordance with NFA documentation. See dot point 2 below for further information on NFA documentation that falls into the exemption category.

4. Process

	Procedure
- Where the clinical team determines admission/activation, the referral document is filed in the NMHS MH (buff) medical record according to the NMHS MH Clinical Record Documentation Procedure. - NB. Where any interaction/interview took place between the client and a member of a clinical team (whether face to face or by telephone or other means), this constitutes a contact between the client and the healthcare provider. <i>In these instances, despite the outcome of 'NFA', the referral documents must be stored as part of a permanent medical record with the Health Service in accordance with minimum storage requirements for psychiatric records (7 years after patient death).</i> The referral is included in the clinical record in accordance with the NMHS MH Clinical Record Documentation policy. - NFA documents (not falling into the exception category outlined in the previous dot point above) must be kept after date of receipt for a minimum of 2 years. An exception applies to Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islanders where the NFA referral documents must be retained indefinitely as per the WA Health Patient Information Retention and Disposal Schedule (DA 2019-008). - Where referrals are reviewed by the clinical team and admission / activation is deemed as 'not indicated', this decision is recorded in Psychiatric Services On-Line Information System (PSOLIS) as 'NFA', the referrer and client is advised of the outcome; and the referral documents filed in either the NMHSMH (buff) medical record or temporary file in accordance with the State Records Act 2000. The Act requires government organisations to have an approved recordkeeping plan	Filing of No Further Action (NFA) referrals - All NFA referrals are to be filed in either the NMHS MH (buff) file or a temporary file. See scenarios below for further guidance. <u>TEMPORARY FILE</u> - If the client has never been referred previously – create and file all information in a temporary file - If the client has been referred previously and therefore already has a temporary file, the information is filed alongside any previous referrals in the temporary file. <u>NMHS MH (BUFF) MEDICAL RECORD</u> - If a client has previously been activated, they will have a buff medical record and any referral documents are filed in the existing NMHS MH medical record. - If a client has been a client in another service within NMHS MH and no longer active – request buff medical record from the other Service and file the new referral documents into the existing buff file - If a client is active with another service – send all information to the Service for them to review and file in their existing buff medical record at the Service Temporary File Requirements - Temporary files are created using card document folders with an affixed plastic 'Mediclip' - Temporary files are to be stored in a secure area or cabinet accessible to staff members with authorised access. These temporary files should where possible stored in a medical record

	Procedure
setting out the matters about which they will create records and how these records will be kept.	filing room <i>in close proximity to</i> active client medical records (which are filed in buff medical record covers). - Temporary files are created under a 'T' number, current year and filing number/order of processing i.e. T18-126 - When there is insufficient storage space at the service, documents are to be stored offsite in archive storage boxes as per NMHSMH Clinical Record Management & Storage Policy and Archiving of Clinical and Other Records or Document Policy

5. Compliance, monitoring and evaluation

Every two years, all temporary files must be audited by checking PSOLIS service events against the NFA referral to determine whether any face to face or phone interactions has occurred between the client and any health care provider of that service. If an interaction has occurred within two years, the NFA referral cannot be destroyed as it becomes part of the client's permanent medical record. If no interactions occurred within the two years after date of receipt, then the NFA referral documentation can be destroyed in accordance with [NMHS Healthcare Record Management Policy](#).

Related internal policies, procedures and guidelines
MH Archiving of Clinical and Other Records or Documents Policy MH Clinical Record Documentation Policy

Policy Sponsor	Director of Clinical Services MHPHDS				
Policy Contact	Manager, Area Health Information NMHS MH				
Date First Issued:	22/05/2013	Last Reviewed:	05/10/2022	Review Date:	05/10/2025
Approved by:	Director of Clinical Services MHPHDS			Date:	05/10/2022
Endorsed by:	Director of Clinical Services MHPHDS			Date:	05/10/2022
NSQHS Standards Applicable:	☒  Std 1: Clinical Governance ☐  Std 2: Partnering with Consumers ☐  Std 3: Preventing and Controlling Healthcare Associated Infection ☐  Std 4: Medication Safety		☐  Std 5: Comprehensive Care ☐  Std 6: Communicating for Safety ☐  Std 7: Blood Management ☐  Std 8: Recognising and Responding to Acute Deterioration		
National Standards for Mental Health Services	☒ Std 1: Rights and Responsibilities ☐ Std 2: Safety ☐ Std 3: Consumer and Carer Participation ☐ Std 4: Diversity Responsibility ☐ Std 5: Promotion and Prevention ☐ Std 6: Consumers ☐ Std 7: Carers ☐ Std 8: Governance, leadership and management		☐ Std 9: Integration ☐ Std 10: Delivery of Care ☐ 10.1 Supporting Recovery ☐ 10.2 Access ☐ 10.3 Entry ☐ 10.4 Assessment and Review ☐ 10.5 Treatment and Support ☐ 10.6 Exit and Re-entry		
Chief Psychiatrist's Standards for Clinical Care:	Physical Health Care of Mental Health Consumers, Transfer of Care				
Printed or personally saved electronic copies of this document are considered uncontrolled					

Document Version Control			
Date	Version	Author	Notes
22/05/2013	1.0	MHEG	Initial endorsement

27/08/2018	2.0	Manager, Area Health Information MHPHDS	Change of policy title. Updated template, inclusion of information regarding requirements for storing No Further Action referrals where interview/interaction took place between clinical team members and the client, despite client not being activated into service. References added for related NMHS MH policies which address storage and retention requirements for those referrals which need to be kept as part of the client's permanent medical record
05/10/2022	3.0	Manager, Area Health Information MHPHDS	Scheduled review, minimal content change, exceptions for non-actions refers beyond 2-year retention period, template and hyperlinks updated

This document can be made available in alternative formats on request for a person with a disability.

© North Metropolitan Health Service 2021

Copyright to this material is vested in the State of Western Australia unless otherwise indicated. Apart from any fair dealing for the purposes of private study, research, criticism or review, as permitted under the provisions of the *Copyright Act 1968*, no part may be reproduced or re-used for any purposes whatsoever without written permission of the State of Western Australia.